Ma’ali, who, in turn, dispatched him on this murderous mission.

History might have been less divided on the matter if Akbar had permitted an investigation, but he didn’t. Instead, he ordered the assassin ‘quickly torn to pieces lest a group of the imperial family be accused in the affair’.[14]

It was only some eighteen months since Akbar had suffered betrayal from those he considered his own. This year, he didn’t want to know.

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The number of Akbar’s detractors would grow until the very end of his life; but so too would his realm. Sharafuddin’s desertion, for example, only served to increase Akbar’s territory: the troops he sent after his insurgent brother-in-law not only retained the fortress of Merta, which Sharafuddin had conquered some years previously, but also took the fort of Jodhpur nearby. This may have been particularly pleasing news to Akbar’s ears – Jodhpur was then ruled by Chandrasen, son of the Raja Maldeo who had caused Humayun and Hamida such distress during their desperate exile in the desert.

The fury of the ataka khail at Shamsuddin’s murder, too, Akbar was able to channel in a more productive, though unscrupulous, direction. He sent them off to depose Sultan Adam of the Gakkhars, the man who had imprisoned the vagabond Kamran and handed him over to Humayun. A young Akbar had travelled to Gakkhar territory with his father, shared a watermelon of amity with Humayun, Kamran and, indeed, Sultan Adam. He must have known, or realized by now, that if Kamran had remained free to launch his untiring assaults on Kabul, Humayun could not have ventured a return to Hindustan. The family owed a debt to the Gakkhar sultan.

And yet, Akbar betrayed the man. As it happens, Sultan Adam’s estranged nephew, Kamal Khan, was a favourite of Akbar’s. Shortly before Sharafuddin’s rebellion, Kamal Khan claimed the Gakkhar throne, and Akbar declared that Sultan Adam must share his kingdom with his nephew. In his telling of the tale, Abul Fazl makes only the most oblique reference to the obligation Akbar owed the sultan, dismissing his long-ago ‘small service’ as hardly worth talking about. The sultan would not have forgotten, however; and besides, he was the ruler of an independent realm, why should he listen to Akbar’s orders? Sultan Adam refused to give half his